

# TECH NIGHTMARES Windows XP

Here are a few things you probably hate about XP—and what to do about them

## 1. XP searches are way too slow

Windows XP runs on the NTFS file system, which is designed for fast indexing and searching. By default, every folder you create is indexed by XP's Indexing Service for fast searching. You would expect that XP knows where your files are, and would serve them up in a jiffy when you do a search. But hey, what do you find? Searching seems to take just as long as in Windows 98. There are numerous options in the Search menu—such as the date the file was modified, and so on. Even then, when you search for, say, image files over 1 MB in size—XP looks for it in all drives, and even in the Windows folder, when it should know that there are no such files in the Windows folder.

**Solution:** Download and install the Google Desktop Search tool. You can find it at <http://desktop.google.com>. It brings up search results much faster, and does its indexing silently, in the background. The only hitch is that results are not always completely up-to-date; for example, say you name a file "digit.txt" in the morning, and rename it to "digit2.txt" in the afternoon. Now, a search for "digit.txt" would show up the old, non-existent file, and clicking on it will bring up an error that says that the file no longer exists.

If, for some reason, you don't like the Google Desktop, there are other programs available that do the same job, such as The Sleuthhound!, available at [www.isleuthhound.com](http://www.isleuthhound.com). One advantage of The Sleuthhound! is that there is support for intranets, which the Google Desktop Search currently does not have.

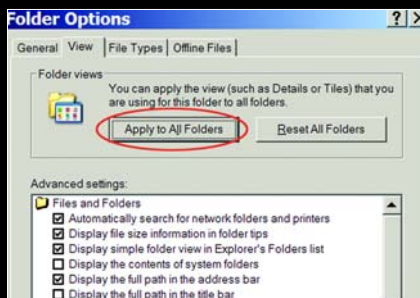
## 2. My Folders All Look Different!

Folders in XP seem to show up in a random sort of way, some with icons, some with thumbnails, and so on. This can become confusing, especially if you have recently migrated from Windows 98—where everything was displayed as icons by default.

**Solution:** To view all your folders the same way, just open a folder, and click on the "Views" button to the extreme right. Here, select what you want to be displayed—thumbnails, or details, or

whatever. Now, go to Tools > Folder options. In the "View" tab, click on the "Apply to all folders" button, and in the dialog box that comes up, click "OK."

You can also group items in a folder according to your preferences—right-



Make all your folders look the same and avoid the confusion and chaos

click in a folder, select "Arrange icons by," and click "Show in groups." This can be used in conjunction with the standard sorting methods—by name, or by date, and so on. For example, if you arrange icons by name and then choose "Show in groups," you'll see files grouped according to letters.

Furthermore, if the thumbnail view is irritating (the thumbnails are just too large), you can resize them. Download the TweakUI utility for XP, available at [www.microsoft.com/windowsxp/downloads/powertoys/xppowertoys.msp](http://www.microsoft.com/windowsxp/downloads/powertoys/xppowertoys.msp). In TweakUI, expand the "Explorer" branch, and select "Thumbnails." Here, change "Size" to 32.

## 3. The cluttered Start Menu

If you have a lot of programs installed, clicking on "All Programs" in the Start Menu will bring up a huge list.

**Solution:** You can drag and drop the applications you use most often into the space right above "All Programs." First, go to Control Panel > Taskbar and Start Menu. Here, in the "Start Menu" tab, click "Customize." Set the "Number of programs on Start menu" to 0. Click "OK" twice. Now go to "All Programs," and pull the programs you want into the empty space above "All Programs." From now on, you won't need to click "All Programs" very often.

## 4. The Irritating Autorun Feature

In XP, when you pop in an Autorun-enabled CD or DVD into your drive, a dialog box comes up asking you what to



Get rid of this irritating thing that pops up whenever you insert a CD or DVD

do: open using a certain program, and so on. What's worse is that there are several types of CDs that XP recognises—and even if you say "Take no action" and tick the box that says to always do the same thing, it may still pop up the next time.

**Solution:** To avoid the pop-up from coming up, right-click the drive icon for your CD or DVD drive, and select Properties. Choose the AutoPlay tab, and choose the desired action for each type of CD. For example, you can choose "Music CD," and then click "Select an action to perform," then select "Take no action." Do a "Take no action" for every type of disk.

## 5. The Low Disk Space Warning

When one of your drives runs low on disk space, XP constantly reminds you about it. After two or three times it can get really irritating.

**Solution:** Run regedit, open HKEY\_CURRENT\_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Policies\Explorer. Create a DWORD and call it "NoLow DiskSpaceChecks," if it's not already there. Double-click on "NoLow DiskSpaceChecks," enter the value "1," and press OK. If the DWORD was already there, change its value to "1." ■  
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